



“India is a priority market for the company. It’s also a great opportunity not just to monetise [WhatsApp] but also to do game-changing innovation. UPI... is going to be a massive opportunity”

SANDHYA DEVANATHAN
VICE PRESIDENT & HEAD, META INDIA



“India is a cluttered market and it will be an uphill task for Meta from a monetisation standpoint. They have customers because it’s free...Only 30-40 million households have a willingness to pay”

BARNIK CHITRAN MAITRA
MANAGING PARTNER,
ARTHUR D. LITTLE

‘user-initiated’ conversations, and ₹0.48 for ‘business-initiated’ ones. BSPs are third-party solution providers with expertise on the WhatsApp Business platform in managing communications for the approved use cases of customer support and time-sensitive, personalised notifications, etc.

One of the first online marketplaces to come on board around two years ago—using Gupshup as a partner—was MakeMyTrip’s redBus, which has around 50,000 buses on its platform. “The kind of reach WhatsApp brings is mindboggling. If there’s commerce flow on WhatsApp, it can give those users who prefer to book offline a medium to book tickets online,” says its Chief Business Officer Manoj Agarwala. He adds that 40 per cent of its conversations on WhatsApp is in vernacular languages. “If WhatsApp doesn’t give us overall volumes it should definitely give us new users,” he says, adding that redBus expects 30-35 per cent of its new users to come from the platform.

THE WAY AHEAD

Despite the challenges, the Meta team is looking forward to a bright future. It is focussed on building India as a big growth driver. Devanathan says banking, financial services, insurance companies, e-commerce firms, etc. have some obvious use cases, while Srinivasan says speech-to-text is going to be a powerful tool. “There’s a lot more mediums we can explore in India. What generative AI can do for business messaging is transform a set of use cases that were not as valuable for businesses, like customer support,” she says. Agrees Prashant Garg, Partner at consultancy EY. “Mobile communication apps enabled with generative AI can be pivotal in providing enterprise solutions and enhanced customer experiences. It will help mobile communication apps monetise their platforms,” he says.

Channels—the recently-launched one-way broadcast tool for admins to send text, photos, videos and polls to their followers—is being looked at as the company’s next pillar of growth in markets like India, Brazil and Indonesia. “Channels is a potential source of revenue for us and we’ll look to support these admins to monetise their Channels,” says Srinivasan. According to her, the best way to build products is to watch and learn how people are organically using the product. “With innovative features like voice messaging turning big, we just need to keep listening to our customers (pun intended),” Srinivasan says.

But while WhatsApp will keep listening to customers, the big question is: will its customers loosen their purse strings for the company? Meta will certainly hope so. **BT**

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